AI ETHICS

AI and Ethics Dumping

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This lecture introduces the listener to 'ethics dumping', and The TRUST Code–a global code of conduct for equitable research relationships. Two cases are provided: one where AI intended to improve the situation of the marginalized, but achieved the opposite, and one case of AI and ethics dumping. For beginners, an overview of AI ethics in 5 minutes is given at the start (thanks to Prof. Bernd Stahl and Dr Kate Chatfield for providing comments on this clip).

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Lecture Transcript

0:07 Hello, my name is Doris Schroeder. My background is in Economics, Philosophy and Politics. And this module is about AI and ethics dumping. At the end of it, you will know what ethics dumping is, and how this topic is relevant to AI, especially to AI research and innovation. Rather than a one piece lecture, the module has four parts. First, you will see a clip entitled "AI Ethics in 5 Minutes". Experts in AI ethics can skip this part. We are also using this module as well for beginners, so this introduction is important. Then the screen will go blank for a minute for you to think about what ethics dumping might be. The second part is another five minute clip, this time explaining what it is, ethics dumping. In the third part, I will come back to you and present two case studies, so that you can see the relevance of ethics dumping to AI. Another one minute break for you to draw your own conclusions. And finally, I will give you my conclusions. I hope you enjoy it. Thank you very much for your attention.

Part I: AI Ethics in 5 Minutes

1:50 Everybody is talking about AI ethics from the Vatican, to the UNESCO, to media and academics around the world. Some people say AI ethics is just another type of technology ethics, no different from say the ethics of gene editing. Other people say that AI ethics differs from other technology ethics areas. Both are right in some respects. AI is a disruptive technology, which means that it fundamentally changes markets and society, and therefore warrants close ethical attention. But even the car was a disruptive technology. So that's not new. Also some of the ethical challenges of AI repeat themselves.

2:50 For instance, AI enabled automation is predicted to contribute to significant unemployment. But this concern was also shared by the Luddites in response to cost-saving machinery 200 years ago. What makes AI ethics seem to stand out is that very far reaching ethics demands are made. For instance, it is recommended that businesses have dedicated AI ethics committees. Or that regular AI impact assessments are undertaken across all organizations which use AI. Both of these measures were not demanded for other emerging technologies.

3:46 The most obvious difference seems to be the scale of use, which might explain the extent to which AI ethics is pushed globally. For instance, over half of all advanced democracies deploy AI surveillance systems. Whether AI ethics is different from other areas of technology ethics are not, the benefits of AI can be numerous. Hence it's important to get AI ethics right.

4:24 In a book written with Bernd Stahl and Rowena Rodrigues, we focused on seven major AI ethics issues. First unfair and illegal discrimination: bias in recruitment tools is one standard example. Second, privacy violations, for instance, wrongful arrests based on face recognition software. Third, surveillance profiteering involving the unlawful appropriation and commercialization of personal data for profit making. Fourth manipulation. For instance, the political manipulation of voters to win elections. Fifth, health and safety risks, as AI systems can malfunction or be open to adversarial attacks. Sixth, human dignity violations is also raised as an AI ethics issue. For instance, in the context of sex robots. And finally, seven, the potential for ethics dumping related to AI. So what is ethics dumping?

(Pause for reflection. Think: What is ethics dumping?)

Part II: Ethics Dumping

7:08 International collaborative research can be highly beneficial, especially when complex challenges need to be addressed. Yet, international research also has a dark side: ethics dumping. Ethics dumping is a global phenomenon, which involves the “off-shoring” of unethical research from higher to lower income settings. Six types of ethics dumping are currently distinguished, even though others might still emerge. Here are examples for each one. Ethics dumping can be seen in the unfair distribution of benefits and burdens. For example, in 1995, a research team from a US university obtained blood samples from 10s of 1000s of impoverished Chinese villages. A US-based company linked to the university received multi-million dollar investments on the basis of the collected genetic information. This type of ethics dumping is also sometimes called helicopter research, where those from a high income setting fly into a lower income setting to extract resources to be analyzed and used at home.

8:40 Culturally inappropriate conduct is also a form of ethics dumping and such conduct need not be done on purpose. For instance, in many regions of the world, community assent or approval will be necessary before research can be conducted ethically. It is the responsibility of the researcher to find out what is culturally appropriate conduct.

9:10 Probably the best known type of ethics dumping is the application of double standards. To give an example, three clinical trials on cervical cancer screening methods were conducted in India from 1998 to 2015. 254 women in the no screening arm died due to cervical cancer. The no screening control arm would not have been allowed in the US, but was accepted by the US funders for these clinical trials in India. Lack of due diligence is another type of ethics dumping, which can put local research participants at risk. For instance, when personal data collected about sex workers in countries where sex work is illegal.

10:08 Researchers also have to avoid lack of transparency or lack of honesty. For instance, where funding proposals require participation from lower income countries, researchers are recruited with promises of equal rights and equal budgets, which are not honored later. Or research participants are recruited and promised useful feedback on the study, but the researchers do not return and the promises are not kept. The final category of ethics dumping is patronizing conduct. A typical example would be one sided research agenda setting, where researchers from a high income country assume they know what research is required in a lower income country. And then design research the way they think is best. Ethics dumping damages trust and adds unfair burdens onto those who are already burdened.

Part III: Case Studies

11:11 Hello, so here we are again. Now after you've got a better idea of what ethics dumping is. So now we will turn to AI ethics topics in particular, and I'm going to share my screen, just a second.

11:36 Artificial Intelligence is one of the few emerging technologies that are very prominently linked to the UN Sustainable Development Goals. So 17 goals, 193 nations resolved, for instance, to end poverty and to end hunger by 2030 and to leave no one behind. AI for Good is an example of a UN driven platform which organizes global summits to link the SDGs to AI work. And the AI4SDGs is a Chinese-led online service and repository that collects AI projects with an impact on the SDGs. So SDG 2 is, for instance, of particular interest to AI specialists, because it requires the processing of vast data mines for weather forecasting. So the examples of benefits of increased forecast quality could be earlier evacuation in the case of severe weather, or reduced irrigation if, for instance, future rainfall could be forecast with better precision. Seasonal climate forecasting is an AI tool used to predict severe weather, such as droughts and floods, in order to help both policymakers and farmers to address problems in a more anticipatory rather than reactive way.

13:22 If used to support the SDGs, tools, such as seasonal climate forecasting, should benefit those most in need. This is what the SDGs are about. However, research by Lemos and Dilling has shown that there may be problems. They say that the benefits of seasonal climate forecasting mostly reach those that are already more resilient, and as they put it are more research rich and can cope better with hazards and disaster anyway. They give two examples. The first example is from Zimbabwe and Brazil, where poor farmers were denied credit after seasonal climate forecasting results predicted a drought. And the second example, given by Lemos and Dilling was from Peru, where seasonal climate forecasting led to accelerated layoffs of workers in the fishing industry. These two examples show that some of those most in need of not being left behind have suffered as a result of AI technology used for seasonal climate forecasting, which was meant to help those in need.

14:46 I would now like to turn to another case, which is more clearly an ethics dumping or helicopter research case, and which occurred during the crisis namely the height of the Ebola crisis in 2014. During that time, a research team from high income countries requested access to vast amounts of mobile phone data from users in Sierra Leone, Guinea and Liberia to track population movements. The researchers said that they needed the data for public health reasons to track the movement of the virus. Other researchers disagreed and maintained that quantified population movements would not reveal how the Ebola virus spread. Sierra Leone, Guinea and Liberia had no data protection guidelines in place that governed providing large scale access to mobile phone data. So government time during a crisis was spent deliberating whether to provide such access. And in a *Nature* piece, researchers argued that this time should have been spent on helping the escalating crisis.

16:10 Liberia decided to deny access owing to privacy concerns, and the research was undertaken on mobile phone data from Sierra Leone. The data showed that fewer people traveled during the Ebola travel ban, but it did not assist in tracking Ebola. Only a few years afterwards, catastrophic German floods struck the Ahr district and even though almost 200 people died, and it took weeks to track all the disease and the survivors, researchers did not request access to mobile phone data, as far as the literature shows. So even in a crisis setting researchers refrained from doing so in a high income country. I would like you to think about this for a minute now.

(Pause for reflection. What do you think about these cases?)

Part IV: Conclusion

18:09 The cases I talked about form about 10% of the chapter on AI for Good in a book on AI ethics. And the non-carefulness about impact on those most marginalized became clear in the examples on seasonal climate forecasting and the ethics dumping variety of applied double standards in the research from the case in the Ebola crisis. The book chapter also draws further conclusions relevant to those who want to work in AI ethically. For instance, AI relies on data, machine learning and neural networks only possible with the input of data. Only an estimated 10% of Africans in rural areas have access to the internet, a figure that goes up to just 22% of urban populations. So any AI application that uses data generated by people who have access to the internet will hit a major obstacle in terms of equity. To apply AI to the SDGs makes the shortage of AI talent even more visible, as these fields are less lucrative than more commercially oriented sectors. And the shortage is already extreme in the commercial sectors.

19:42 Then there is the problem of the social determinants of health for instance. An AI application that was developed to identify those people who would benefit from pre-exposure HIV prophylaxis, made this mistake. So they identified people but then didn't take into account that these drugs, if given to people who are facing food insecurity and hunger, are very unlikely to achieve an impact due to adherence problems. When taking these drugs whilst suffering from food insecurity, extreme stomach pains are the result. And hence adherence to the drug regime that was advised by the AI tool is difficult.

20:37 AI practitioners cannot solve all of those problems, but AI innovators can consider the impact of their innovations on the most marginalized, and AI researchers can avoid ethics dumping. As a bonus clip, you will now be introduced to the TRUST Code, a global code of conduct for equitable research partnerships. The Code provides advice on how to avoid ethics dumping, and has been a success around the world.

(video segment)

21:24 The TRUST Code, a global code of conduct for equitable research partnerships was developed by 13 partner teams and 12 advisors from all continents.The majority of team leaders were women and the majority of partner teams were from middle or lower middle income countries. Invaluable input was provided by two communities that are vulnerable to exploitation in research: sex workers from Kenya and indigenous peoples from

South Africa. The code is based on a risk analysis of the potential for exploitation in international research. 88 risks were identified and dealt with in the code. After its launch in the European Parliament, the code was adopted by the European Commission and since then by other high profile adopters. The code is short, precise and clear, so that it can be used by all stakeholders, including those who are at risk of exploitation.

24:02 I hope you enjoyed this clip and also the module, and I hope that you belong to the generation of AI practitioners and researchers who want to do AI work ethically. Thank you very much for your attention. Bye-bye.